

Roasted butternut squash and shallot soup

Beautiful and extremely nutritious, this soup has it all: color, consistency, and flavor as well as an **outstanding** garnish. The soup is easy to make and can be prepared ahead of time and reheated. A sweet apple or a couple of potatoes can easily be substituted for or added to the pear. The garnishes require a little more work, but they make the soup unforgettable.

4 large shallots, coarsely chopped

1 Bosc pear, peeled, cored, and coarsely chopped

2 teaspoons olive oil

2 teaspoons dried rubbed sage

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1 large butternut squash, 3 to 3½ pounds
[1.5 to 1.75kg]

6 ounces silken tofu [180g]

½ cup dry white wine [125ml]

4 cups vegetable stock or water [1L]

3 tablespoons fresh lemon juice

3 to 4 tablespoons canola or safflower oil

36 fresh sage leaves

1. **Preheat** the oven to 375°F [190°C]. Line 2 large baking sheets with aluminum foil or parchment paper. In a bowl, toss the shallots and pear with 1 teaspoon of the olive oil and the dried sage. Season lightly with salt and pepper. Spread over one of the baking sheets. Bake for 20 to 30 minutes, or until the shallots and pear are soft and lightly browned.
2. **Split** the squash with a large knife; scoop out and reserve the seeds. Lightly coat the cut sides of the squash with the remaining olive oil and place it face down on the other baking sheet. Bake for 35 minutes, or until a sharp knife slips through the squash like butter.

3. Rinse the reserved squash seeds under cold running water, removing any orange fibers; drain and let dry. **Coat** the seeds lightly with olive oil and a sprinkling of salt. Scatter them over the same baking sheet and return to the oven until well browned, 10 to 15 minutes. Set aside.
4. Scoop the meat from the squash or simply peel off the skin. In a blender, **puree** the squash, shallots, pear, tofu, wine, and stock in batches. If desired, add additional liquid to attain a lighter consistency. Pour into a soup pot and bring to a boil. Reduce the heat and simmer for 10 minutes. Season generously with salt and pepper. Add the lemon juice and cook over low heat for another 5 minutes.
5. While the soup is cooking, in a medium frying pan **heat** the canola oil over medium-high heat until almost smoking. (Test the oil to make sure it's hot enough by dropping one sage leaf into it. If the sage sizzles immediately, the oil is ready.) In small batches, fry the fresh sage leaves until crisp and lightly browned, 15 to 20 seconds. Remove with a slotted spoon and drain on paper towels.
6. To serve, **ladle** the soup into bowls and float 2 to 3 sage leaves on top. Place a few toasted squash seeds in the middle of each. Serve immediately.

SERVES 10 TO 12